

way to prevent spyware from covertly accessing and transmitting critical corporate information. Similarly, organisations whose Help Desk resources are burdened to correct, often by 're-imaging' entire systems thereby preventing the corruption of the desktop computing environments. The security measures currently in place in most organisations—a combination of a firewall, antivirus software, and spyware/adware removal programs—do not adequately address the threat of spyware. Since firewalls operate at the boundary of the network, they have no visibility into the spyware running inside the network. Anti-virus solutions are not adequate either, since anti-virus software typically doesn't include spyware signatures and cannot prevent spyware from transmitting information. And spyware removal programs, which are targeted to individual consumers not organisations, do not provide a centrally managed solution and do not adequately address the burden of application conflicts. Organisations need a way to keep spyware from gaining access to their systems in the first place. To do this, organisations must be able to prevent employees from visiting sites that distribute spyware and from downloading applications that are infected with spyware. For spyware that may be brought on to the desktops through other channels, such as home or mobile laptop use, or via CDs or eFlash drives, organisations also need a way to stop spyware from ever launching, thereby protecting the corruption of that desktop, as well as preventing the transmission of data back to host servers.

Some spyware programs collect information using 'keystroke loggers', which capture information about the user's computer activities, including cookies and time spent on certain sites. Some capture all keystrokes users make; others are more focused, recording Web sites visited, passwords, e-mails, credit card numbers, and so on. Most keyloggers are invisible and save recorded keystrokes into a log file that is transmitted periodically back to the host server. Some can even record both sides of instant messaging chat conversations (for example, MSN Messenger and Yahoo! Messenger).

Spyware can also read a computer's unique hardware ID num-